



A thought for today

You stick a credit card in a machine, and you pay \$3 or whatever it is to get cash – your own money

BILL JANKLOW

Free UPI, Forever

It's become India's main currency. Letting payments firms milk it now would be short-sighted

UPI is arguably India's biggest success. It is the world's largest real-time payment platform. Almost half of such payments, globally, happen on it. In absolute terms, there were more than 24,000cr UPI transactions in 2025-26, altogether worth ₹314L cr. For perspective, India's GDP last fiscal was ₹346.4L cr. How did UPI grow so big? There are many reasons, but the one that spurred its growth most was removal of MDR or 'merchant discount rate'. That's the fee banks and other intermediaries charge to make UPI payments go through. When MDR was waived, UPI became "digital cash", so even grocers and autowallahs started accepting it.

Now, UPI is India's main currency. So, it's odd that govt wants to restore MDR on it. The finance minister moved a bill on Tuesday to allow this. If The Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill passes, UPI payments over ₹2,000 to merchants could face MDR of 0.25%-0.4%. That doesn't sound like much. On ₹2,000, the MDR would be "just" ₹5-₹8. And as govt says, only 5% of UPI merchant payments involve sums greater than ₹2,000. Still, the move sounds unfair on principle.

Why is MDR needed? Payments industry claims processing UPI transactions is costly. They have to spend on servers, software, staff, fees, etc. But there's no transparency about the per transaction cost. We can only guess: govt subsidy for 95% of UPI merchant transactions – those below ₹2,000 – was ₹2,196cr last fiscal. The other 5% surely can't cost more. In which case, UPI is already paying for itself many times over.

Consider this: in 2025-26, RBI destroyed 1,700cr spoil notes, and spent ₹4,875cr on printing fresh currency. How much more would it have spent on currency if we didn't have UPI? But printing is the smallest cost of physical cash – it has to be sorted, transported, stored, authenticated. Have banks considered how many thousand crores UPI has saved them in staff costs and rent for additional branches and ATMs? A Visa report estimated that cash cost India 1.7% of GDP in 2014-15. Even 0.1% of GDP today amounts to over ₹30,000cr. And then, there's improved tax compliance with increasing digitalisation of payments. So, for the nation, free UPI is a gift that keeps giving. Govt should look at this big picture, and find other ways to compensate financial intermediaries for UPI's costs.

Fuelling More Debate

Withdrawal of auto body's letter on ethanol 'contamination' doesn't help GOI's case

SIAM pulled a letter written to petroleum & natural gas ministry, in which the auto industry body had reportedly flagged contamination in the ethanol supply chain for E20 petrol. The letter, per reports, was written after investigation of cases of corrosive damage in fuel system and exhaust components of vehicles using E20 fuel – an issue linked to chloride-contaminated ethanol, and exposure to moisture. The letter also reported cases of vehicles stalling soon after refuelling, likely because moisture caused the ethanol and petrol to separate. The withdrawal of SIAM's letter, coming on top of GOI's less-than-convincing efforts to address motorists' and industry's concerns about E20's rollout, heightens public concern over using the blended fuel. To the issues of – 1) drop in mileage, 2) quandary of motorists owning older vehicles, and 3) govt claims and their counters – add another. If ethanol is contaminated, the risk of damage to cars, even those manufactured after 2023, making them "E20-compliant", grows manifold.

Earlier, petrol pump dealers had asked GOI for better testing equipment and clear guidelines, saying they lack the tools to properly check E20 fuel quality. Question is, who is listening?

Ministry's constant thrum has been to say concerns are overblown. GOI claims E20 is efficient, but motorists care about cost per km, not just price per litre. When mileage falls, savings at the pump are offset. Govt claimed no compatibility issues, but as is evident, "can run" and "designed for" are different standards. On July 30, GOI assured Parliament that transition to E20 was "undertaken after successful validation of fuel systems, engine durability, drivability, material compatibility..." It makes sense, therefore, to make this extensive data public. What seems clear is this: many motorists' on-road experience is at variance with GOI's claims. Lack of transparency only expands the room for continued debate.

Gaali Girls

Some questions on shame and kshama

Bachi Karkaria

Nixon created 'Expletives Deleted'. Trump patented 'Expletives Repeated'. But we *Bharatiyas* are *shudh shakahari in bhasha*. Our men are entitled to leeway, but our girls have to be *sattrik*, never *slutvik*. However, being more evolved than the decadent, short-haired West, we forgive the misled, especially the misled. As borne out by last weekend's magnanimous response to the Cockyroaches.

But, not everyone is on the same script. After patriotically excising all traces of colonialism, are we now to turn Victorian? Make our girls too repeat, 'Prunes, prisms and poetry to say, A wilful young woman must learn to obey'?

Will popular 'Tales for Rebel Girls' be tamed by our textbook tartars? Will Rani Lakshmbai of Jhansi be cancelled? Ditto 12th-century, Kannada, gender-bender, *vachana* poet Akka Mahadevi? She defied patriarchy; she shed all worldly possessions, including clothing; refused arranged marriage, to a king no less, and considered Shiv her only true husband. Will even Meerabai be banned? She did more or less the same, no, wandering around yearning after 'cowherd' Krishna?

Then, what about 'Queen' Kangana? In her break-out film didn't she *bindaas* jazz off to a solo honeymoon instead of the expected 'Hai, hai, barbaad ho gayi!' breast-beating after being ditched at the *mandap*? Does her 'Gutter Generation' not count as 'a drain inspector's report' – to borrow Gandhiji's caustic comment on *Mother India*, Katherine Mayo's 1927 book – on our women's status?

Is it okay for trolls to threaten rape?

Desh dudes' daily 'ma-bhen' spit-out is not even considered a *gaali*, but an exasperated girl's outburst is an unlawful act?

Can Gen Z have its own four-letter words?

Jeez!, should proud Hindusites be borrowing from the Bible? Like 'Turn the other cheek on the cheeky'? Or 'Father forgives them for they know not what to say'.

Will the next Bhaktwood hit-song be 'Jumma, *kshama de de*'?

Alec Smart said: "Kanwariyas will again block carwariyas."

Zero FIR: Zero Logic

A girl spoke unparliamentary words at Jantar Mantar. Yes, those words deserve criticism. But greater mischief is done by the case against her, filed by a person without locus standi, at a police station without jurisdiction, against the grain of multiple Supreme Court judgments

Saurabh Gupta & Aditya Prasanna Bhattacharya



Let us begin with the obvious. The words spoken about PM at Jantar Mantar on July 23 were crude. It is no secret that they rebutted no policy and answered no argument. A protest that had already forced a Union minister to resign on the strength of its grievance was diminished by them, not helped. They deserve condemnation.

On July 29, Noida police registered a zero FIR against the girl who spoke them. A zero FIR is one recorded at a station that has no local jurisdiction and then transferred onward, in this case, to Delhi.

The sections invoked were 352, 353(1) and 356(1) of Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, dealing with insult, public mischief and defamation respectively. The complaint came not from the person spoken about, but from a lawyer who had watched a video. The reasoning was that those words lowered the dignity of a constitutional office.

To see what is wrong with this FIR, look at where these three provisions came from. All of them descend from Macaulay's Penal Code, enacted in 1860.

Section 356, defamation, was section 499 of that Code. Macaulay took the English law of libel and slander, collapsed its two branches into a single offence, and made it a crime to harm a person's reputation. Section 352 was section 504: intentional insult that is likely to provoke the person insulted into breaking the peace. Section 353 was section 505: statements that spread panic among the public or incite others to disorder.

Read together, the pattern is plain. Each provision guards against concrete harm, a ruined reputation, a brawl, a public disturbance. Not one of them is meant to protect the dignity of an office.

The Supreme Court has kept these sections tethered to that purpose. On insult, it has held for decades that mere abuse, rudeness, or discourtesy will not do. The words must be likely to provoke the person insulted into a breach of the peace. On public mischief, intention is the heart of the offence.

In Balwant Singh (1995), the court acquitted two men who had shouted secessionist slogans in Chandigarh, on the evening of Indira Gandhi's assassination, holding that slogans raised casually, without the intent or the tendency to incite disorder, are not a crime. The court had famously remarked that in fact, oversensitiveness on the part of law enforcement, in tense situations such as these, invites trouble, and not the offensive speech itself.

On defamation, when the Court upheld the provision in Subramanian Swamy (2016), it did so on a narrow ground: that the offence protects an individual's reputation, which is part of his personal dignity. Reputation, in other words, belongs to a person.

Now apply this to the words at Jantar

he had also forgiven the accused person in his own video message. The reaction of a crowd is not the test. The statute asks about the person addressed, and he was far away.

Next, *public mischief*. That fares no better. The offence requires an intention to cause fear or alarm to the public, or to set one group against another. Crude abuse of a leader at a protest, however ugly, does not endanger public tranquillity. If shouting for the break-up of the country hours after one PM's assassination did not clear that bar, heckling another does not come close.

Finally, *defamation*. That's the strangest charge of the three. Reputation belongs to persons, not to institutions. One cannot defame the dignity of an office.

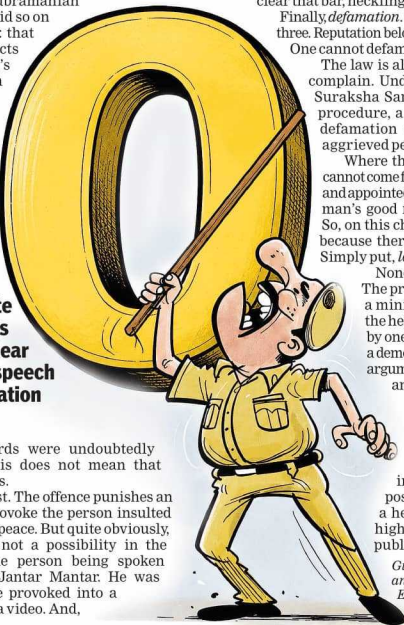
The law is also very explicit about who may complain. Under the new Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, which governs criminal procedure, a court may take cognisance of defamation only on a complaint by the aggrieved person.

Where that person is PM, the complaint cannot come from a lawyer who watched a video, and appointed himself the guardian of another man's good name. PM has not complained. So, on this charge there is no case to answer, because there is no one entitled to bring it. Simply put, *locus standi* is missing.

None of this excuses what was said. The protest was strong enough to force a minister from office. It did not need the help of slurs, and it was cheapened by one. But the answer to bad speech in a democracy is condemnation and better argument, both of which were available and both of which followed.

The criminal law is a blunt instrument, and it is being asked here to do a job these sections were never built for: to shield a public office from insult. Turning our brand new postcolonial criminal laws against a heckler to protect the dignity of high office is, if anything, the real public mischief.

Gupta is a practising Advocate (India) and a Solicitor of the Senior Courts of England and Wales. Bhattacharya is Lead, Vidhi Bengal



Offensive words by themselves do not constitute an offence under law. India's new criminal code is very clear on this. The answer to bad speech in a democracy is condemnation and better argument

Mantar. The words were undoubtedly offensive, but this does not mean that they were offences.

Take *insult* first. The offence punishes an insult likely to provoke the person insulted into breaking the peace. But quite obviously, this was simply not a possibility in the present case. The person being spoken about wasn't at Jantar Mantar. He was never going to be provoked into a public dispute by a video. And,

Revolutionising Office Commute: View From An E-Scooter

Their cost, convenience, and size make them the best option for work runs. Dedicated lanes, new designs, and better safety could dramatically ease road congestion, even saving money for city authorities

Sujit John@timesofindia.com



For four years, I've been using an electric scooter to commute to work. Till before the Covid lockdown, I commuted mostly by public bus. Post-Covid, Bengaluru bus corporation's fleet had reduced, and buses were congested. I considered my options, including the near impossibility of getting car parking near my office. And finally decided on a scooter, despite dire warnings: "Really! At this age!"

Office is 19km from home. And thereide can get boring. Unlike in a car where you can listen to music or podcasts, it's not that simple on a scooter – helmets and eyeglasses integrated with Bluetooth speakers are expensive, though quality cheaper ones are in the works. Rain and harsh sun can be dampeners too.

But these aside, I'm loving my scooter. I love it most when I squeeze through long queues of cars stuck in a jam. Google map estimations invariably show two-wheelers taking 10-20 minutes less time than cars for distances of 15-25km in the city's notorious traffic conditions. I estimate I save 88 to 132 hours of driving a year compared to using a car.

I love the ease of parking. Electric acceleration is phenomenal. The scooter has great software features, including a lovely Google map on the dashboard that now even tells me which roads are smoother. The latest software update allows me to talk to my scooter naturally to set routes, make and manage calls, adjust settings, and control media without taking my hands off the handlebar.

And the cost is unbelievable. My office

provides free charging. So, operational cost is zero – barring when I take it in for routine service every 5,000km, when I typically pay less than ₹1,000. A colleague who bought an electric scooter eight years ago, has taken it for routine service once every two years, and has needed just one part replacement – a brake lever. An electric scooter has about 1,000 to 2,000 fewer moving and wearable parts (like pistons, valves, and gears) compared

Yet, progress is abysmally slow.

A car is made to carry at least 4-5 people, and 2-4 suitcases. But more than 90% of the time, it's used by one person with a single bag. Any factory operating at that capacity would be shut down in months. Yet, we pamper cars by building bigger roads at huge costs.

In comparison, a two-wheeler is already a very efficient vehicle in terms of road space. It's extremely convenient



to a traditional internal combustion engine (ICE) scooter. And there's no internal fluid changes required. So, typical maintenance is limited to standard wear-and-tear items like brakes, tyres, and battery health checks.

That brings me to a larger point. EVs are upending the economics of urban transportation. Many of us concerned about the environment romanticise cycling and walking. But neither is viable for office commute in our mega cities. We also live in hope that we can build a public transport system so good that those using personal vehicles will move to them.

– it doesn't have last-mile connectivity issues. And now, with the electric versions, they are in many cases more affordable than a bus or metro.

Assuming a purchase cost of ₹1.3L for a two-wheeler, an 8-year lifespan, and accounting for forgone compound interest, and estimates of charging/fuel, and maintenance costs for electric and ICE scooters, my calculations suggest that for a 20km daily commute, an electric scooter costs ₹87 a day, and a petrol scooter ₹143 a day. This explains why electric two-wheelers are rapidly replacing ICE ones.

Calvin & Hobbes



Anandmurti Gurumaa

In the pursuit of Self-realisation, there is a common yet subtle trap: the aspiration to simply be a 'good person'. We often measure our progress by a checklist of virtues – harming no one, giving to charity, and maintaining a pleasant demeanour.

We convince ourselves that moral correctness is the ultimate destination, using our good deeds as a shield against the deeper, more uncomfortable work of self-inquiry. Is social nicety truly the peak of human potential, or are we merely decorating a prison with pleasant behaviour?

If you simply want to be 'good', then a cucumber is also good. A mango is very good. The pineapple is so good, and a pistachio ice cream is marvellously

good. There is no transformative power in that kind of good. Without realising your own identity, just being a 'good person' is often one way of running away from truth. It is running away from the hard work of seeing how entangled and disillusioned the mind truly is.

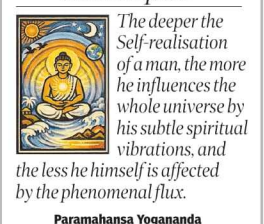
That is why there are millions who say, "I just want to be a good person. I do good things, I don't harm anybody, I give charity to my church or my temple, and I help orphans. Isn't it good?" But good is not enough. The factual, realistic encounter with our own true identity is required. It is not just about keeping the mind quiet for some hours, days, or weeks, only for the mind to go back to those same affairs. It

is not about temporarily quieting the mind; it is about realising the reality of your own being, your own existence.

If you haven't practised various techniques of meditation, all the wandering to different spiritual places – you realise that you go there, you practise, and you feel good about it. But again, it is just feeling good about your mind. You think, 'My mind is so quiet, so nice.' But when the retreat ends, you are still facing the demon of your own mind because the root cause has not been extinguished.

Consider a child who thinks there is a ghost in the tree, or in the house, or in the attic. There is a weird creaky sound, so the child becomes convinced there is a ghost. But in the daytime, the child is

Sacred space



The deeper the Self-realisation of a man, the more he influences the whole universe by his subtle spiritual vibrations, and the less he himself is affected by the phenomenal flux.

Paramahansa Yogananda

Being Good Is Not Good Enough

not afraid. At night, there is darkness, and the mind goes wild in that darkness, creating imaginative figures and becoming self-hypnotised that there is something out to kill or harm.

If we don't remove that darkness, fear of the ghost will always be there. Every night, the child will run away from the attic, believing the place is haunted. But it is not the place that is haunted; it is the mind which is haunted.

It is nice to be on the path, to find things, to experience and explore. But what is more important is removing the veil of darkness from the mind. That is what is required. Knowing *about* truth is not the same as *living* it. Do not just be a seeker of information. You must do the hard work to dispel the darkness entirely.



THE SPEAKING TREE